

PDF file name: ILL article-Urban Myths and Rural Legends

Original article word count: 674

Extracted content word count: 1026 (152% of the original word count)

Title of the article: *Urban Myths and Rural Legends: An Alternate Take on the Regionalism of Hip Hop*

The content extracted is as follows:

To date, locational studies that explicitly deal with regional-rural hip hop are limited,¹ although Minestrelli's work on Australian Indigenous hip hop richly delves into the intertwined relationships between First Nations, music, and the land.

Regional-rural pockets omit the intensity of speed and esthetic experienced in the metropolis and catalyze an alternative bricolage of hip-hop practice.

By locating the West Country of the UK's regional-rural hip-hop origins, this article explores a three-fold inquiry.

The article concludes that the production of hip hop in the West Country evolves differently from that of metro-centric artists, and the regional-rural construction of hip-hop coexists as a vehicle for negotiating broader socio-geographical acceptance and affirming a regional identity.

From Urban to Rural

As stated by old.british.hiphop.co.uk: As with so much of hip-hop's early history, as well as what was happening in New York the developing scene in the UK was and remains undocumented. Records weren't really released, it was all about the live show and rocking parties and nobody thought to detail all that was evolving (18).⁴ Yet in regional-rural areas, opportunities for live shows were almost nil due to the sparseness of hip-hop followers and lack of demand for events.

I am reminded of occasions in the park where we would be told angrily to turn off that rap crap by elder dog-walkers; hostile comments fueled by the worst in parochialist attitude and a deeply concerning naivete about hip hop and its emerging global identity as a black, urban culture threatening a dominantly white, rural way of life.

From Consumers to Producers

The heavy reliance on products rather than the processes of hip hop meant that the first regional-rural practitioners learnt their practice by undertaking detailed analysis and an almost forensic unpacking of hip-hop's relations.

The records that these first-generation regional-rural hip-hop adopters breakdanced to were visually, sonically, and lyrically laden with tropes, symbols, and representations of the urban.

The mobility of these recorded artifacts carried the myth of the urban to the country, a myth upon which the first biographies of regional-rural hip-hop practitioners was built.

With only these visual reference points, regional-rural dwellers assumed the urban fabric as a singular hip-hop context, which although unknowingly self-limiting, was hugely significant in grounding their embryonic practice.

The limitations of regional-rural dwellers in accessing a wider breadth of hip-hop culture during its early years meant that they needed to buy into these narrower scopes of representation.

Through this restricted consumption of hip-hop culture, a new habitus evolved which initially drew upon the ideology of hip-hop in American urban life but was later reimagined and practiced in the sphere of the regional-rural.

In response to Bourdieu's habitus, the primary system which classifies practices and ultimately taste (167), is the structure of the regional-rural practices associated with convention and tradition in the West Country; there is inherently a social placing of these practices and their correlating artifacts, which in turn relate to taste, and ultimately class.⁵ To then examine the habitus of the regional-rural hip-hop practitioner in a similar way, the aforementioned hip-hop tropes aid a framing of habitus, but the imagined urbanism projected by hip-hop's relations influence the construction of the regional-rural habitus.

These relations become the correlating artifacts of the habitus, and when coupled with

direct regional-rural hip-hop praxis, the habitus of the regional-rural hip-hop practitioner abridges imagined urban experience, engagement with secondary artifacts, and primary regional-rural practice.

In turn, this new hip-hop habitus evolves through responding to its local regional-rural traditions and the continuing development of glocal hip-hop culture.

These structural inequalities, cultivated through lack of access to hip-hop sources and primary experience of high urbanism, resulted in the habitus of West Country hip-hop differing greatly from those of its urban counterpart. What is critical here, is that throughout the lifespan of West Country hip-hop, the anchor of its habitus shifted from urban ideologies to everyday regional-rural practices.

The West Country hip-hop habitus reexamined the class conditions in its environment, firstly through the lens of artifacts embedded with urban ideologies, and secondly through the lens of its own emerging regional-rural hip-hop practice.

Over the course of three decades, the habitus of West Country hip-hop, although historically anchored by the myth of urban life and everyday regional-rural practices, formed its own biography via the modes of production that distinguished itself from local traditions and rituals and from urban ideologies.

Check the Dialect

Artists from disparate regional-rural locations are confronted with a challenge in how they control their vocals, and in how they speak to their own vernacular and the acquired argot of hip-hop. This relates to what is arguably the most critical aspect of rap music that creates distance from other music genres—the notion of keeping it real associated with ideas of authenticity and identity.

These notions of authenticity are both intertwined and dialectical, and in terms of West Country hip-hop the shift in perception from the myth of the urban to the reality of the regional-rural carried great impact on the local hip-hop community.

Conclusion: Divergency and Negotiation through Hip Hop

Regional-rural hip-hop in the West Country took almost three decades to craft its own language.

It negotiates between established regional-rural vernacular conventions and the younger traditions of hip-hop; and each dialectical turn generates a creative response which fuels the progression of regional-rural hip-hop. It refutes the myth of hip-hop purely as urban culture, demonstrated in the anti-street lyrics: .

Furthermore, this enveloping of the regional-rural again challenges the myth of hip-hop as pure urban culture.

Hip-hop reimaginings of this nature undoubtably occur in an array of regional-rural contexts, and the potential for cross-related studies of these contexts may ignite a greater discussion that hip-hop culture is desperate for: one which reaches out from the cities to rurality, and by doing so deepens our understanding of hip-hop's potential as an engine for the progression and conservation of broader culture itself.